Distressing Event Nomination: Trauma in the Lives of College Students

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Abstract

The prevalence of trauma exposure in college students (N = 2,763) was assessed using the Traumatic Life Events Questionnaire (TLEQ) or open-ended questions in different samples. The types of events that students nominated as their worst event differed depending on the type of question that they were asked. Students nominated the death of a loved one as their most traumatic event when the TLEQ was used. However, when open-ended questions were employed, students nominated events related to education and work as their most traumatic events. Also events nominated differed somewhat among students from different racial groups. These results show that studies using the TLEQ may be excluding some events that college students deem as traumatic and that certain racial groups may be more at risk for certain types of trauma.

Introduction

In the United States, approximately one-third of the 18 to 24 age-group is presently in college (as cited in[1]). College represents a time of transition in the lives of many students and perhaps this factors into why younger individuals report more traumatic events than older individuals[2]. As a result, studies have specifically explored trauma exposure in college samples. The most popular way to measure trauma is by using a trauma checklist such as the Traumatic Life Events Questionnaire (TLEQ), although several other checklists are used as well [3]. Checklists typically only measure Criterion A events, which occur when an individual "experienced an event that involved actual or threatened death, serious injury, or threat to physical integrity of self or others"[4]. The exclusion of non-criterion A events can be problematic because these events can be just as distressing as Criterion A events[5]. Thus recent studies have shown that these checklists may not be conducive to measuring every traumatic experience that college students encounter[4].

Research Questions

1. When using the TLEQ measure or open ended questions, are the events that people nominate as their most traumatic different?
2. Do ethnic minorities differ in the events that they nominate as worst events?

Method

Participants

➢4 samples of undergraduate students, (total *N* = 2,763) participated in this study. There were 832 males and 1928 females (three people did not identify as either). In regards to race and ethnicity, 80% identified as White (N=2200), 11% as Asian (N=295) and 4% as Black (N=110). The remaining racial categories were listed by 2% or less of the sample.

Measures

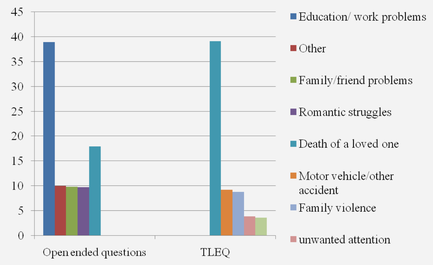
➢Traumatic events were assessed using the TLEQ and open-ended questions. The TLEQ listed 22 events and one "other" category and asked participants which of the events they had experienced caused the most distress. Open-ended questions simply asked students what was the most traumatic event they had experienced in their lifetime. Open-ended responses were coded into 35 categories (23 TLEQ + additional categories) and combined into 18 categories to simplify analysis.

Procedure

➢Participants were recruited from University Psychology classes. Data were collected from students using online surveys that used either the TLEQ (N=2080) or an open-ended question (N=683).

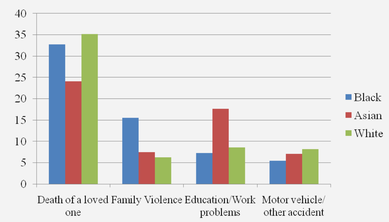
Results

Figure 1



A Chi Square test revealed that the events that participants nominated as their most traumatic experience differed depending on the type of measure that was utilized, $\chi 2\ (1) = 1515.41$, $p<.0001$. When an open-ended question was asked, events related to an educational or work related problem were the most traumatic events selected (see Figure 1). Alternatively the death of a loved one was the most traumatic event endorsed when the TLEQ was used (see Figure 1). Coincidentally, the death of a loved one is the only event that appeared in the top five nominated events using either the TLEQ or open-ended questions. Of the events nominated by participants following an open-ended question, 60% were not included on the TLEQ.

Figure 2



A Chi square test also showed that the events that participants nominated as their worst event also differed to some extent by race , $\chi 2\ (36) = 93.61$, $p<.0001$. The death of a loved one was the worst traumatic experience for each race and the highest among whites (Figure 2). Of the other top nominated events, blacks experienced the most family violence, Asians the most educational/work problems and whites the most motor vehicle/other accident (Figure 2).

Discussion

- The results of our study reveal that the events that college students endorse as their most distressing differ based on the types of measures that are used.
- Open-ended questions allow for participants to describe events that are not restricted to the category of criterion A events, which may explain why event nomination is different.
- The freedom that open-ended questions allow can create troubles as well. Participants may be more inclined to describe traumatic events that are more novel and simply forget or fail to mention experiences of their past even though they may undeniably have been more traumatic.
- The findings of our study are consistent with another study [6].
- In our sample different racial groups were found to state different traumatic events as their worst experiences.
- These findings are limited by the diversity of the sample studied. The majority of the participants in our study were white and therefore the ability to generalize across racial groups is in question.

Conclusions & Future Directions

A new type of measure that amalgamates traumatic events that commonly confront students during their college experience in addition to frequent events that people may experience over the course their lifetime would allow for researchers to learn more about trauma exposure in college students. More knowledge could lead to more answers about why college students are at risk for trauma exposure and also preventative measures could be developed to lessen the impact of such experiences.

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